

Interview with Agostino Ghiglia - "A Digital Civic Education Against Web Manipulations"
Interview with Agostino Ghiglia, member of the Authority for the Protection of Personal Data
(by Massimiliano Cannata, Corriere delle Alpi, January 4, 2024)

"Today, our young people between the ages of eight and nineteen spend more than half of their waking life online. An anthropological phenomenon that has unprecedented implications. From the moment we wake up and check the time on our phones, we create our virtual twin, which grows with us throughout the day. In the Information Society, the individual is a 'data' that becomes the object of aggression, manipulation, commodification, exchange, and violence." Agostino Ghiglia, a member of the Board of the Authority for the Protection of Personal Data, has published "Digital Civic Education" (with the collaboration of Alessandra Genisio and Silvia Sequi, publisher Apogeo), a manual intended to help readers navigate the open sea of the Internet.

How did this original publishing project come about?

"The digital age should not be seen as a mere evolution of the web; it is a cultural revolution, a new discovery of fire that affects our entire being. We must return to the ABC, the essential alphabet that has guided us since childhood in understanding and reading the world to orient ourselves. Not knowing the 'new alphabets' sufficiently is akin to not being able to control one's mother tongue. This is a widespread phenomenon, which sees Italy in a position of serious backwardness."

What can be done concretely to raise the level of security in the use of digital tools?

"I would like to limit myself to a few examples. The Authority has limited the use of three chatbots this year alone; two years ago, we were forced to block TikTok because it had insufficient mechanisms for age verification. Most platforms lack protective measures; they are effectively open gates, out of control. For this reason, we are working in concert with Agcom to develop age verification processes. We have blocked the use of 'Replika,' a sentimental chatbot that, after an initial friendly approach, encourages users to go further by asking for sums of money, without any guarantees in terms of the security of sensitive data processing."

Recently, the Authority issued an alert to limit web scraping. What is it about, and what do users risk concretely?

"It is an exploratory investigation into public and private websites carried out to verify the adoption of appropriate security measures to prevent the mass collection of personal data for the training of artificial intelligence algorithms by third parties. This indiscriminate gathering of information is conducted without our knowledge to understand habits, tastes, interests, and activities that pertain to our most intimate sphere. The recent prohibition issued by Mediaset to OpenAI to use data available on its corporate websites to 'train algorithms' is set to set a precedent and inaugurate a trend that will certainly take hold in the near future."

What prospects does the recent approval of the AI Act open up for a European digital policy?

"It is very difficult to formulate a judgment. We are faced with a law that will have a long implementation timeline. Therefore, many doubts remain about its effectiveness. The development of generative AI is moving at supersonic speed, an aspect that was underestimated before the intervention of the Italian Authority to limit ChatGPT last March. What will happen in the coming years? Will the 'Gatekeepers' voluntarily adhere to a whole series of rules and self-limitations to protect the fundamental rights of individuals, or will the fear, evoked by many, that Europe will fall behind China and the USA prevail and influence the states that will have to write the final version? Europe was the first to regulate AI, an undeniable fact, but how this primacy will impact the global landscape is still to be seen."